El Mozote

By Andrea Gibson

El Salvador, 1981.
In the village of El Mozote
the twilight sun was falling slow
behind the mountain's red earth.
December soil giving birth
to the stretching necks of noble pines, rising
falling shedding humble shadows upon the golden corn
fields below

but the day's tender glow told nothing
of the dark fear of the people
hiding horrified in their homes.
And then the soldiers came.

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INTRODUCTION

In December 1981 soldiers of the Salvadoran Army's select, American-trained Atlacatl Battalion entered the village of El Mozote, where they murdered hundreds of men, women, and children, often by decapitation. Although reports of the massacre -- and photographs of its victims -- appeared in the United States, the Reagan administration quickly dismissed them as propaganda. In the end, El Mozote was forgotten. The war in El Salvador continued, with American funding. This poem serves as a testament to the forgotten victims of a neglected theater of the cold war. El Mozote by Andrea Gibson.

The soldiers came in the name of cleansing,
cleansing their country free
of potential communist rebels.
Plan was, if they couldn't catch the fish
then they were gonna drain the sea.
So they pounded on the village doors
with the butts of their M16s,
"Get out here now!"
'til every person in the village was mouth-down in the dirt.

And the soldiers shouted questions

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while mothers trembled and the children cried
and the fathers begged for their lives,
begged for their families to live, "We are an innocent
people,
we have not taken sides, we have no answers to give."

And they had no answers to give.
So when night dropped its ebony skirt
the people of El Mozote were still
mouth-down in the dirt.
And there had never been a night so long,
sleepess with terror, the darkness drew on and on
so when dawn finally sprinkled her first shards of light
the people of the village
having lived through the night
dared, for a moment, hope.
But no.
The slaughter began with the men.
Fathers, brothers, grandfathers, sons,
not one was left alive.
Beheaded with machetes, their crimson corpses

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were stacked and stacked and stacked in piles,
while each mother clutched her child to her chest
praying, "Jesus save us, Jesus save us."
They couldn't imagine the terror coming next.

The children were hung from trees,
tossed in the air and caught
on the bloodied blades of bayonets.
The women were slaughtered with M16s,
as there ten-year-old daughters
writhed in heaving pain beneath the soldiers' brutal sex,
Their screams futile as the soft seams of their flesh
tore and ripped to fit the gang-raping warheads
of a sin no god would ever forgive.

And there has never been a sound more terrible,
more impossibly unbearable
than the desperate shrill of the death
piercing hour after hour the miles of El Salvador's hillls,
and still, beneath it all,
like breath rises from shattered chests

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and wings rise from burning nests
beneath it all
one little girl sang.

Cristo me ama, bien lo se
(Jesus loves me, this I know)

Through the slaughter of their father
and the slaughter of her mother,
a day howling a horror like no other
she sang.

Su palabra me hace ver
(For the Bible tells me so)

As soldier after soldier drilled her body
with his phallic hate,
she sang through rape after rape after brutal rape,
as everything around her bled desperate with cries
the little girl sang hymns to the sky.

Que los ninos son de aquel
(Little ones to Him belong)

She sang 'til they shot her in the chest,
and still she sang like the blessed of the blessed.

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She sang 'til they shot her again
and even then as she choked on her blood she sang.

Quien es nuestro amigo fiel
(They are weak but He is strong)

She sang 'til they slit her throat.

Yes, Jesus loves me
Yes, Jesus loves me
Yes, Jesus loves me
The Bible tells me so

And she was only one of over 900 innocent people
tortured and killed that day at the massacre at El Mozote,
funded by the USA.
A crime covered up and denied by our government for years
because killers were trained
in the School of the Americas, Ft. Benning, Georgia.

And now as the militia of the red, white, and blue
treads the guilty waters of another bloody slaughter
our nation's government is still hiding

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still denying its people honest information.

But we who walk among the land of the relatively free

have an obligation to hunt down the truth,

have an obligation to lift our voices against any more

pain

inflicted on anyone in our names.

Our resistance is the key.

The caged bird sings.

The caged bird would rather be free.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

Colorado State Qualifier

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